

7.3 Getting More Effects

We don't live in the dark ages of audio editing any more—you don't need a million editing programs just so you can have the widest choices of effects. For a much wider choice of effects, you can extend nearly any audio editor thanks to a standard plugin architecture called VST—Virtual Studio Technology.

7.3.1 What are VST Plugins?

Virtual Studio Technology (VST) is a standard interface by which effects can be loaded into any audio editing program. The architecture was developed by German company Steinberg, and has found immense popularity. At a conservative estimate, at least 1,500 VST effects exist, most of them free of cost.

The purpose of the VST effect is to replace as much of the recording studio's hardware as possible to create a Virtual Studio. In the second version of the VST architecture, Steinberg introduced the ability to send MIDI data to the audio editing program, thus giving rise to the VST Instrument. As the name suggests, VST Instruments can simulate MIDI synthesizers to let you create your own music on-the-fly. Most VST effects work in real-time, so you'll need a considerably powerful processor to run them.

7.3.2 Where do I get them?

A simple Google search will take you to a gaggle of Web sites where you can get free VST plugins. Here are a few that caught our attention:

AudiOracle (www.audioracle.com/freetrials.php)

VST Instruments ranging from the extremely useful to the utterly pointless and fun. You will also find plenty of resources and articles on audio editing, as well as a forum where you can discuss audio with other members.

Tweakbench (www.tweakbench.com)

Tweakbench has a collection of weirdly-named VST Effects and Instruments. Choose from drum kits, tone generators and many more.